



Self-defense

Animals can run from their predators, but plants have no way of escaping hungry plant eaters. Instead, they have developed some clever ways of making themselves look and taste as unappealing or dangerous as possible, encouraging animals to look elsewhere for a meal. Plant defenses range from spiky thorns to toxic chemicals.



Camel thorn

Fully developed thorns may grow up to 2 1/4 in (6 cm) long.

Needlelike crystals line the blue agave's leaves, making them an unpleasant mouthful.



Silver-gray crystals

Spiky leaf edges protect these succulent leaves.



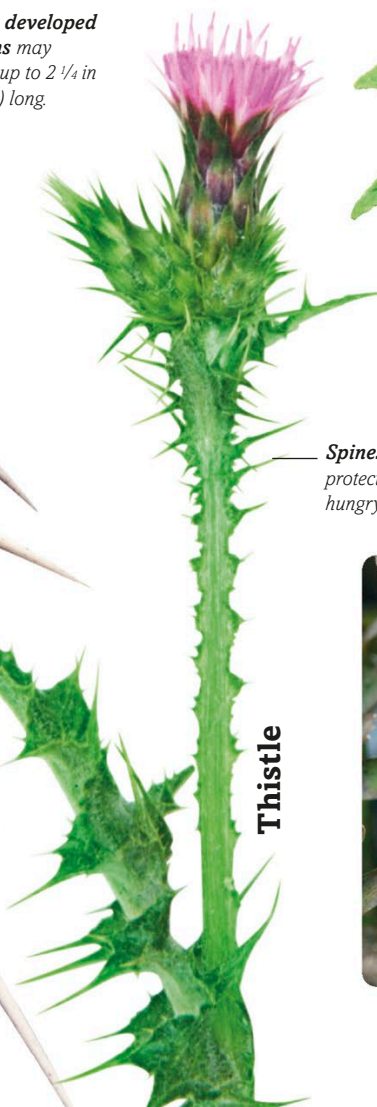
Blue agave

Tea leaves contain tannin, a bitter-tasting chemical that deters animals from eating them.

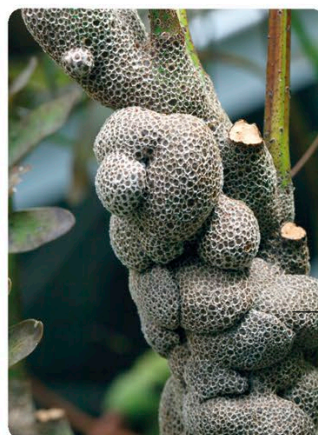


Tea

Spines on the stem protect the plant from hungry animals.



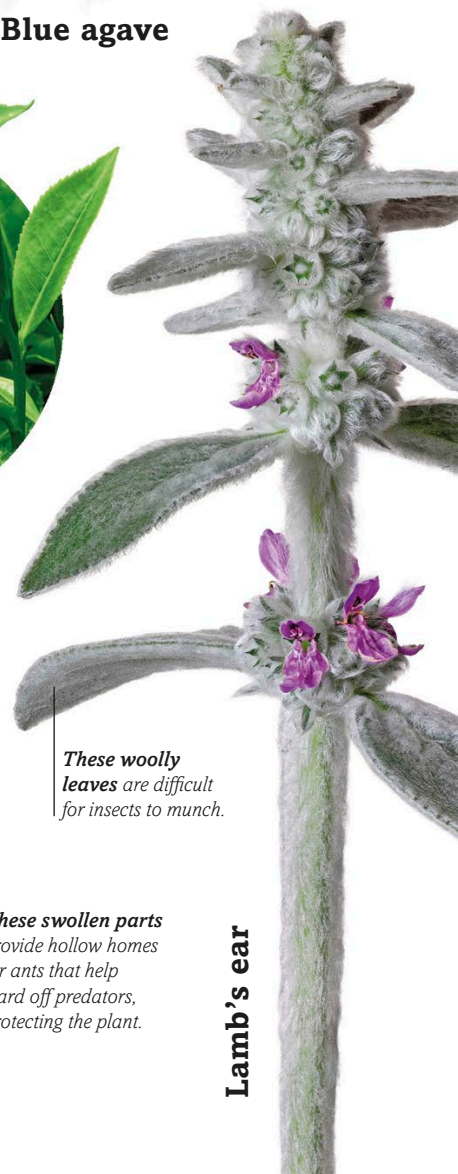
Thistle



Ant fern

These swollen parts provide hollow homes for ants that help ward off predators, protecting the plant.

These woolly leaves are difficult for insects to munch.



Lamb's ear